Propane is an odourless and highly inflammable gas. It is heavier than air. It is liquefied through pressurisation and commonly used as LPG (Liquefied Petroleum Gas) along with butane. Propane is used as fuel in heating, cooking and vehicles. Propane can also be used as refrigerants.



Figure 15.3 LPG Cylinders

DO YOU KNOW?

Propane is used in LPG cylinders. Since it is an odouress gas, any leakage cannot be detected. Hence, a chemical by name Mercaptan is mixed with LPG to help in detection of any leakage of LPG.

Butane is a gas at room temperature and atmospheric pressure. They are highly flammable, colorless gases that quickly vaporize at room temperature. Butane is used as a fuel gas and propellant in aerosol sprays such as deodorants. Pure forms of butane can be used as refrigerants. Butane is also used as lighter fuel for a common lighter or butane torch.

Pentanes are liquids with low boiling point. They are used as fuels and solvents in the laboratory. They are also used to produce polystyrene.

15.2 Natural Gas

Natural gas is a naturally occurring hydrocarbon gas mixture consisting primarily of methane along with other higher alkanes and a small percentage of carbon dioxide, nitrogen and hydrogen sulphide (H_2S). If the natural gas contains lower hydrocarbons like methane and ethane, it is called dry gas. If higher hydrocarbons like propane and butane are also present in the gas, it is called wet gas.

Natural gas is always found above the oil in the oil wells. This gas is trapped inside the small spaces in underground rocks called reservoirs. Conventional natural gas can be extracted through drilling wells. Natural gas can also be found in reservoirs with oil and is extracted along with oil. This is called associated gas.

Natural gas is a fossil fuel used as a source of energy for heating, cooking and electricity generation. Natural gas occurs in Tripura, Rajasthan, Maharashtra, Andhra Pradesh (Krishna, Godavari Basins) and Tamil Nadu (Cauveri Delta). It is also formed by the decomposition of organic matter in marshy areas and waste sewages. The natural gas formed by this way contains mainly methane.

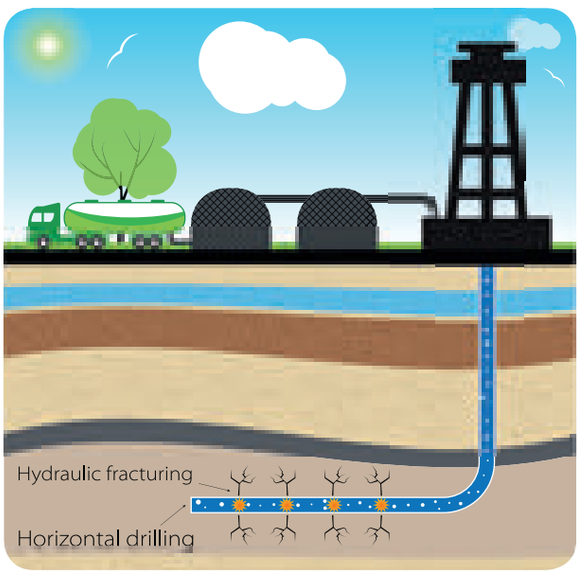


Figure 15.4 Extraction of natural gas

Activity 2

Take a glass bottle and put some leaves, twigs, waste paper and saw-dust in it. Pour some water in it and keep it for 20 days. Open the bottle and bring a glowing splinter near the mouth. You can see a gas burning near the mouth showing its combustible nature. It is due to the evolution of natural gas.

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